

AI Data Center Pocket Ledger Card

Before you fight about AI data centers, clear the ledger.

Print version. Public review tool, not legal advice.

The method in three lines

Promise is not payment. Growth is not settlement. A public bill needs a named payer.

Five hearing questions

1. What is being built, and who owns it?
2. Which legal entity promises to pay?
3. What happens at 60 percent load?
4. What happens if it exits in year five?
5. Who pays if the contract, guarantee, or flexibility claim fails?

Three traps

- Press release is not contract.
- Tax revenue is not electric-bill protection.
- PJM market pathway is not project bill.

Ask for five documents

1. Service agreement or tariff schedule.
2. Cost-to-serve or cost-allocation study.
3. Minimum bill, exit fee, collateral, guarantee.
4. RTO/capacity or resource-obligation evidence.
5. Local tax, water, roads, schools, safety, mitigation.

If confidential, ask who can review under protective order.

Do not misuse

- Unknown is not proof of subsidy.
- One clean ledger is not a clean project.
- Policy support explains why a project may proceed; payment settlement explains who pays.

Ninety-second opening line: I am not asking whether AI is good or bad tonight. I am asking whether the payment chain is clear before public balance sheets are used.